

Second Order ODEs

The **general form** of a second order ODE is

$$\frac{d^2y}{dt^2} = f(t, y, \frac{dy}{dt})$$

for some given function f .

1 Linear Homogeneous Equations

Definition 1.1 (Linear Equation).

A second order ODE is called **linear** if it can be written in the form

$$a(t) \cdot y'' + b(t) \cdot y' + c(t) \cdot y = g(t)$$

If $a(t) \neq 0$, we can divide both sides by $a(t)$ to get $y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = r(t)$.

Definition 1.2 (Homogeneous Equation).

A linear equation is called **homogeneous** if it can be written in the form

$$a(t) \cdot y'' + b(t) \cdot y' + c(t) \cdot y = 0$$

Otherwise, it is called **non-homogeneous**.

Theorem 1.1 (Existence and Uniqueness Theorem).

Consider the IVP:

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = r(t), \quad y(t_0) = y_0, \quad y'(t_0) = y_1$$

if there exists an open interval $I \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ such that $t_0 \in I$ and p , q and r are **continuous** on I , then there is a **exact one** solution $y = \phi(t)$, and it exists **throughout** I .

Theorem 1.2 (Principle of Superposition).

If y_1 and y_2 are two solutions of the **homogeneous equation**

$$a(t) \cdot y'' + b(t) \cdot y' + c(t) \cdot y = 0$$

then any linear combination $c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t)$ is also a solution of the ODE.

Definition 1.3 (Wronskian).

The **Wronskian**, or **Wronskian determinant**, of two functions y_1 and y_2 is defined as

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t) := \begin{vmatrix} y_1(t) & y_2(t) \\ y_1'(t) & y_2'(t) \end{vmatrix} = y_1(t) \cdot y_2'(t) - y_2(t) \cdot y_1'(t)$$

Theorem 1.3 (Abel's Theorem).

Suppose $p(t)$ and $q(t)$ are continuous on an open interval I , and y_1 and y_2 are two non-zero solutions of the ODE

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0 \quad (1)$$

Then, the Wronskian of y_1 and y_2 is given by

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t) = c \cdot \exp\left(-\int p(t) dt\right) \quad \text{where } c \in \mathbb{R} \text{ is a constant depending on } y_1, y_2$$

Remark. If $y(t), p(t), q(t) \in \mathbb{C}$, then $c \in \mathbb{C}$.

Corollary

$$\exists t_0 \in I \text{ s.t. } W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \implies \forall t \in I, W(y_1, y_2)(t) \neq 0$$

Proof (Abel's Theorem).

$$\begin{aligned} \begin{cases} y_2 y_1'' + y_2 p y_1' + y_2 q y_1 = 0 \\ y_1 y_2'' + y_1 p y_2' + y_1 q y_2 = 0 \end{cases} &\implies (y_2 y_1'' - y_1 y_2'') + p \cdot (y_2 y_1' - y_1 y_2') = 0 \\ &\implies W' + p \cdot W = 0 \\ &\implies |W(t)| = \exp\left(-\int p(t) dt\right) \quad \text{or} \quad W(t) = 0 \end{aligned}$$

□

Theorem 1.4 (Linear Dependence and Wronskian).

Suppose y_1 and y_2 are two solutions of an ODE in the form of eq. (1). Then,

$$y_1(t) \text{ and } y_2(t) \text{ are linearly independent on } t \in I \iff \forall t \in I, W(y_1, y_2)(t) \neq 0$$

Proof.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{linear independence} &\iff \forall c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{C}, \left(c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t) = 0 \right) \rightarrow \left(c_1 = c_2 = 0 \right) && [\text{Proposition 1}] \\ &\iff \forall c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{C}, \begin{bmatrix} y_1(t) & y_2(t) \\ y_1'(t) & y_2'(t) \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} \rightarrow \begin{bmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} && [\text{Proposition 2}] \\ &\iff W(y_1, y_2)(t) \neq 0 \\ &\iff \forall t \in I, W(y_1, y_2)(t) \neq 0 \quad \text{by the corollary of Abel's Theorem} \end{aligned}$$

([Proposition 2] $\implies$ [Proposition 1]) is obtained by combining [Proposition 2] with the following fact:

$$\forall c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{C}, \left(c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t) = 0 \right) \rightarrow \left(c_1 y_1'(t) + c_2 y_2'(t) = 0 \right)$$

□

Theorem 1.5.

Suppose $p(t)$ and $q(t)$ are continuous on an open interval I , and y_1 and y_2 are two solutions of the ODE

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0 \quad \text{for } t \in I \quad (2)$$

Let $\phi(t)$ be the **unique** solution (by Theorem 1.1) of the IVP:

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0 \quad y(t_0) = m, \quad y'(t_0) = n \quad \text{for } t \in I \text{ and } t_0 \in I \quad (3)$$

Then, for $t \in I$,

$$\exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \phi(t) = c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t) \iff W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \quad (4)$$

Remark. In the assumption, y_1 and y_2 are not required to be linearly independent. Thus c_1, c_2 are required to be unique in the left hand side of eq. (4).

Proof.

Sufficiency. Since $\phi(t_0) = m$ and $\phi'(t_0) = n$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \phi(t) = c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t) &\implies \exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \begin{bmatrix} y_1(t_0) & y_2(t_0) \\ y_1'(t_0) & y_2'(t_0) \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} m \\ n \end{bmatrix} \\ &\implies \exists b_1, b_2 \in \mathbb{R}, \exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \begin{bmatrix} y_1(t_0) & y_2(t_0) \\ y_1'(t_0) & y_2'(t_0) \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} b_1 \\ b_2 \end{bmatrix} \\ &\iff W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \end{aligned}$$

Necessity.

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \implies \exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \begin{bmatrix} y_1(t_0) & y_2(t_0) \\ y_1'(t_0) & y_2'(t_0) \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} m \\ n \end{bmatrix}$$

Let $\varphi(t) := c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t), t \in I$. Then we have $\varphi(t_0) = m$ and $\varphi'(t_0) = n$.

Theorem 1.2 (Principle of Superposition) $\implies \varphi(t)$ is a solution of the ODE eq. (2).

Theorem 1.1 (Existence and Uniqueness Theorem) $\implies \varphi(t)$ is the **only** solution of the IVP in eq. (3).

Thus, $\varphi(t) = \phi(t)$ and we have

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \implies \exists! c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \phi(t) = \varphi(t) = c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t)$$

□

Theorem 1.6.

Suppose $p(t)$ and $q(t)$ are continuous on an open interval I , and y_1 and y_2 are two solutions of ODE

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0$$

for $t \in I$. Then,

The **general solution** is given by $\phi(t) = c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t)$. $\iff \exists t_0 \in I \text{ s.t. } W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0$.

y_1, y_2 are said to form a **fundamental set of solutions (FSS)** of the ODE, if their Wronskian is non-zero.

Remark. Theorem 1.6 is used to determine whether a given pair of solutions y_1, y_2 form a FSS, rather than verifying the existence and form of solutions. An ODE satisfying the condition (continuous coefficients) always has solutions, and the solutions form a 2D vector space. By Theorem 1.4 (Linear Dependence and Wronskian), the linear independence of y_1, y_2 also indicates that they form a FSS.

Proof.

Let S denote the set of all solutions of the ODE. We aim to prove that

$$\forall y \in S, \exists c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } y(t) = c_1 y_1(t) + c_2 y_2(t) \iff \exists t_0 \in I \text{ s.t. } W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0$$

Let $\mathcal{S}_{\text{IVP}}[t^*, m, n]$ denote the solution of the following IVP (by Theorem 1.1, there is exactly one solution):

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0 \quad y(t^*) = m, \quad y'(t^*) = n \quad \text{for } t \in I \text{ and } t^* \in I$$

By Theorem 1.5, we have

$$\forall t_0 \in I \left[\left(W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \right) \leftrightarrow \forall m, n \left(\exists c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \mathcal{S}_{\text{IVP}}[t_0, m, n] = c_1 y_1 + c_2 y_2 \right) \right]$$

Instantiate m, n with $y(t_0), y'(t_0)$ for all $y \in S$:

$$\forall t_0 \in I \left[\left(W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \right) \leftrightarrow \forall y \in S \left(\exists c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } \mathcal{S}_{\text{IVP}}[t_0, y(t_0), y'(t_0)] = c_1 y_1 + c_2 y_2 \right) \right]$$

Since y satisfies the ODE and initial conditions itself, $\mathcal{S}_{\text{IVP}}[t_0, y(t_0), y'(t_0)]$ is identical to y . Thus we obtain

$$\forall t_0 \in I \left[\left(W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \right) \leftrightarrow \forall y \in S \left(\exists c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } y = c_1 y_1 + c_2 y_2 \right) \right] \quad (5)$$

Now we can apply the following corollary from first-order formal logic:

$$\left(\exists x. R(x) \right) \wedge \forall x. \left(R(x) \rightarrow (P(x) \leftrightarrow Q) \right) \implies \left(\exists x. (R(x) \wedge P(x)) \right) \leftrightarrow Q$$

(Note that Q does not depend on x). Identifying $R(x)$ with $x \in I$, $P(x)$ with $W(y_1, y_2)(x) \neq 0$, and noting I is non-empty so that $\exists t_0 \in I$, we can transform eq. (5) into

$$\left(\exists t_0 \in I, W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) \neq 0 \right) \leftrightarrow \forall y \in S \left(\exists c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R} \text{ s.t. } y = c_1 y_1 + c_2 y_2 \right)$$

This completes the proof. □

Theorem 1.7 (Existence of Fundamental Set of Solutions).

If $p(t)$ and $q(t)$ are continuous on an open interval I , then there must exist fundamental sets of solutions for the following ODE:

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0 \quad \text{for } t \in I \quad (6)$$

A FSS can be constructed as follows: Pick any $t_0 \in I$, and let y_1 be the solution of eq. (6) with initial conditions

$$y_1(t_0) = 1, \quad y_1'(t_0) = 0$$

Let y_2 be the solution of eq. (6) with initial conditions

$$y_2(t_0) = 0, \quad y_2'(t_0) = 1$$

Then, y_1 and y_2 form a FSS of eq. (6).

Proof.

Theorem 1.1 (Existence and Uniqueness Theorem) guarantees the existence of y_1 and y_2 . By the definition of Wronskian, we have

$$W(y_1, y_2)(t_0) = \begin{vmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{vmatrix} = 1 \neq 0$$

By the corollary of Abel's Theorem, $W(y_1, y_2)(t) \neq 0$ for all $t \in I$. y_1 and y_2 form a FSS of eq. (6). □

2 Homogeneous Equations with Constant Coefficients

Theorem 2.1.

Given an ODE with **real-valued** coefficients

$$y'' + p(t) \cdot y' + q(t) \cdot y = 0$$

if y is a **complex-valued** solution of the ODE, then $\text{Re}(y), \text{Im}(y)$ are also solutions of the ODE.

Proof.

Substitute $y(t) = u(t) + i v(t)$ into the ODE, and it can be verified that both $u(t)$ and $v(t)$ satisfy the ODE. □

Theorem 2.2.

For the linear ODE with constant coefficients

$$ay'' + by' + cy = 0 \quad (7)$$

the **characteristic equation** is given by

$$ar^2 + br + c = 0$$

Let r_1, r_2 be the two roots and $\Delta := b^2 - 4ac$ be the discriminant. Then,

- If $\Delta > 0$, then $r_1 \neq r_2 \in \mathbb{R}$, and the general solution is given by

$$y(t) = c_1 e^{r_1 t} + c_2 e^{r_2 t}$$

- If $\Delta = 0$, then $r_1 = r_2 \in \mathbb{R}$, and the general solution is given by

$$y(t) = (c_1 + c_2 t) e^{-\frac{b}{2a} t}$$

- If $\Delta < 0$, then $r_1 = \overline{r_2} \in \mathbb{C}$. Let $\lambda := \operatorname{Re}(r_1)$, $\mu := \operatorname{Im}(r_1)$. The general solution is given by

$$y(t) = e^{\lambda t} \left(c_1 \cos(\mu t) + c_2 \sin(\mu t) \right) \quad (\text{real-valued when } a, b, c, c_1, c_2 \in \mathbb{R})$$

$$\text{or } y(t) = e^{\lambda t} \left(c_1 \cos(\mu t) + \mathbf{i} c_2 \sin(\mu t) \right) \quad (\text{complex-valued})$$

Proof.

The general solutions are derived by substituting the ansatz $y(t) = e^{rt}$ into the differential equation and applying Theorem 1.6.

When $\Delta < 0$, the characteristic equation yields complex conjugate roots, leading to complex-valued solutions. However, if the coefficients $a, b, c \in \mathbb{R}$, we may apply Theorem 2.1 to construct an equivalent real-valued general solution.

When $\Delta = 0$, the characteristic equation has a repeated real root r , yielding only one solution $y_1(t) = e^{rt}$. To form a fundamental set of solutions, we require a second linearly independent solution. Using Theorem 1.3 (Abel's Theorem), we can obtain $y_2(t) = te^{rt}$. (*Note: Any solution linearly independent of $y_1(t)$ is acceptable, though te^{rt} is the standard choice.*) $\square$